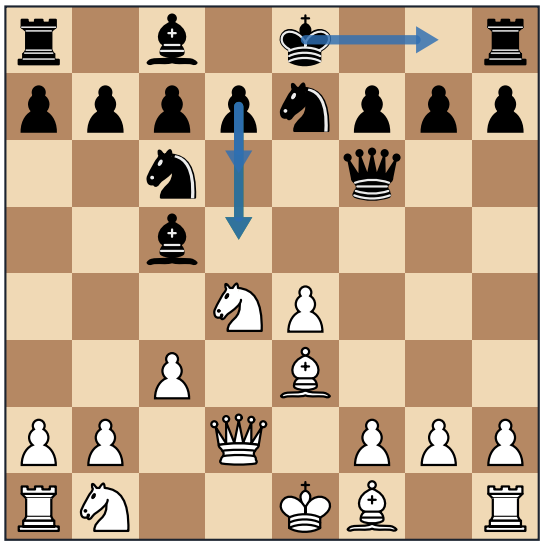
Scotch Game

ECO C44-C45 | 53 named lines | Open games (1.e4 e5)

In one sentence: Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Memory pattern: Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.



Main line: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Nge7 7.Qd2

Key ideas

1. Develop knights before bishops and castle early.
2. Fight for the center with d4 or ...d5 at the right moment.
3. Use gambit ideas (Scotch, King's Gambit, Vienna) only when you know the follow-up tactics.
4. Avoid pawn grabs that cost tempi; watch f7/f2 weaknesses.
5. Trade pieces when ahead; keep tension when your pieces are more active.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.05** (equal, depth 17). Best: d5.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle early; do not leave the king in the center when lines open.
3. Best minor pieces?	Develop knights then bishops; fight for the center and the f7/f2 squares.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
5. What does my opponent want?	The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

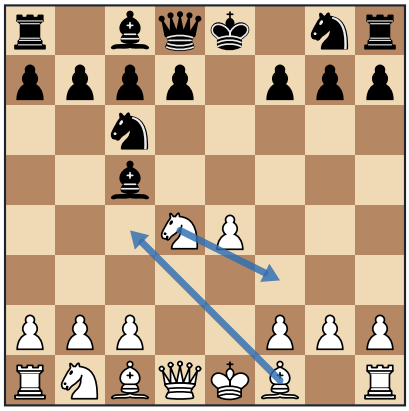
The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Nge7 7.Qd2

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
2... Nc6	Develops the knight to c6.
3. d4	Central break. Occupies the center with a pawn.
3... exd4	Open the center. Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
4. Nxd4	Captures on d4 to trade or win material.
4... Bc5	Active bishop. Develops the bishop to c5.
5. Be3	Develops the bishop to e3.
5... Qf6	Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).
6. c3	Prepare d4. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
6... Nge7	Develops the knight to e7.
7. Qd2	Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).



After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6



After 6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

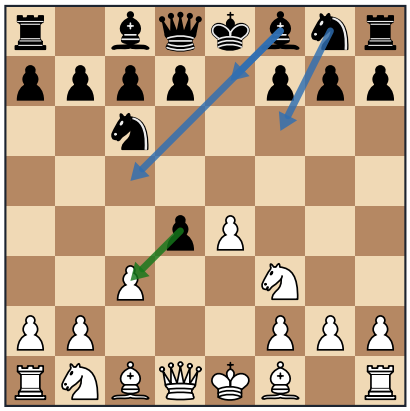


Position after the line

Scotch Gambit C44 | 8 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Bc4`

Stockfish: **+0.00** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: Nf6.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Advance Variation, Cochrane-Anderssen Variation, Dubois Réti Defense, Göring Gambit Declined

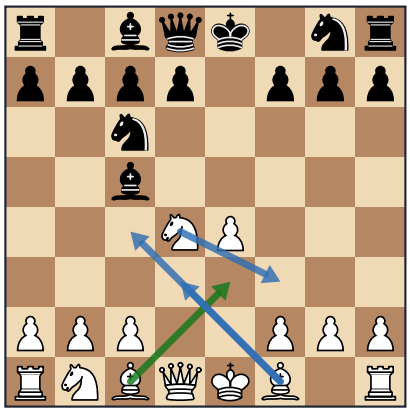


Position after the line

Göring Gambit C44 | 4 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.c3`

Stockfish: **-0.20** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: dxc3.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Bardeleben Variation, Double Pawn Sacrifice, Main Line

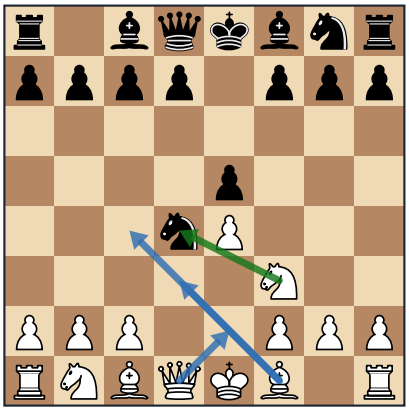


Position after the line

Classical Variation C45 | 4 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5`

Stockfish: **+0.24** (equal, depth 13). Best next move: Be3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)
Sub-variations: Blackburne Attack, Intermezzo Variation, Millennium Variation

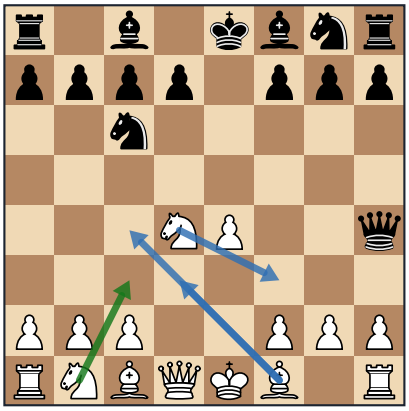


Position after the line

Lolli Variation C44 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 Nxd4`

Stockfish: **+0.79** (clearly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Nxd4.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)

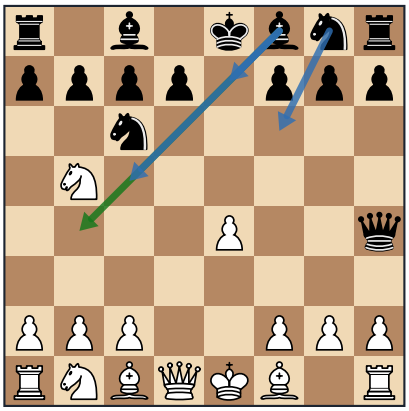


Position after the line

Steinitz Variation C45 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4`

Stockfish: **+0.90** (clearly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Nc3.
What to look for: Nf3 (develop); Nc3 (develop); d4 (central break)



Position after the line

Horwitz Attack C45 | 2 lines

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4 5.Nb5`

Stockfish: **+0.41** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Bb4+.
What to look for: Nc6 (develop); Nf6 (counter e4); d5 (free the position)
Sub-variations: Blackburne Variation

Detailed repertoire notes

Scotch Game (C44-C45, White)

`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nxc6 bxc6 6.e5 Qe7 7.Qe2 Nd5 8.c4 Ba6 9.b3 g6 10.Bb2 Bg7`

Idea: Trade the d-pawn for open lines and a central knight, then use space and the bishops.

Structure: Open game: Black gets doubled c-pawns in Mieses lines; White has e4/e5 space. Pieces, not pawns, decide.

Pieces: Nd4 (or Nxc6), Bc4/Be2, Qe2/Qf3, rooks to d1/e1. Bishops love the open diagonals.

Plan: Develop quickly, castle, and challenge Black's center with c4/f4 or Nd5. If Black plays ...Bc5, use Be3 and Nb5 ideas.

King: Castle kingside quickly; the open center punishes delays. **Opponent:** Active pieces (...Bc5, ...Qh4) and ...Nf6 hitting e4.

Watch out: Do not push e5 prematurely if Black can hit it with ...Qe7/...Nd5 and gain tempi.

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Count your developed pieces versus your opponent's every move. If you are ahead, open the position; if behind, keep it closed or trade.

Why play it

Classical open-game theory: rapid development, central tension and king safety decide the game.

Typical mistakes

- Early queen sorties that lose time.
- Leaving the king in the center when lines are open.
- Grabbing a pawn and falling behind in development.

Typical tactics and traps

- Fried Liver, Legal's Mate and similar f7/f2 tactics.
- Scholar's-style Qh5/Bc4 attacks on f7 if Black ignores them.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Open games reward activity; simplified endings depend on pawn structure and piece activity.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Scotch Game (all lines)** C44
  `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4`
  - **Lolli Variation** C44
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...Nxd4`
  - **Göring Gambit** C44
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.c3`
    - **Double Pawn Sacrifice** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.c3 -> 4...dxc3 5.Bc4`
    - **Main Line** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.c3 -> 4...dxc3 5.Nxc3 Bb4`
    - **Bardeleben Variation** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.c3 -> 4...dxc3 5.Bc4 Nf6 6.Nxc3 Bb4`
  - **Relfsson Gambit** C44
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Bb5`
  - **Scotch Gambit** C44
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Bc4`
    - **Dubois Réti Defense** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.d4 exd4`
    - **Göring Gambit Declined** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.c3 d5`
    - **London Defense** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Bc4 -> 4...Bb4`
    - **Advance Variation** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Bc4 -> 4...Nf6 5.e5`
    - **Sarratt Variation** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Bc4 -> 4...Bc5 5.Ng5`
    - **Kingside Variation** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6 4.d4 exd4 5.e5 Ng4`
    - **Cochrane-Anderssen Variation** C44
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Bc4 -> 4...Bc5 5.O-O d6 6.c3 Bg4`
  - **Benima Defense** C44
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Be7 4.d4 exd4`
  - **Classical Variation** C45
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5`
    - **Intermezzo Variation** C45
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 -> 5.Nxc6 Qf6`
    - **Millennium Variation** C45
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 -> 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Qg6`
    - **Blackburne Attack** C45
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 -> 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Nge7 7.Qd2`
  - **Haxo Gambit** C44
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Bc4 Bc5`
  - **Malaniuk Variation** C45
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Bb4`
  - **Schmidt Variation** C45
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6`
  - **Steinitz Variation** C45
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4`
  - **Alekhine Gambit** C45
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.e5`
  - **Braune Variation** C45
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4 5.Be3`
  - **Fraser Variation** C45
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4 5.Nf3`
  - **Horwitz Attack** C45
    `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4 5.Nb5`
    - **Blackburne Variation** C45
      `1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4 5.Nb5 -> 5...Bb4 6.Bd2 Qxe4 7.Be2 Kd8 8.O-O Bxd2 9.Qxd2`

- **Napoleon Gambit** C44
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...Nxd4 4.Nxd4 exd4 5.Bc4
- **Paulsen Variation** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4 5.Nf5
- **Potter Variation** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Nb3
- **Modern Defense** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4 5.Nc3 Bb4
- **Romanishin Variation** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Nb3 Bb4
- **Blumenfeld Attack** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6 6.Nb5
- **Ghulam-Kassim Variation** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Nxd4 5.Qxd4 d6 6.Bd3
- **Mieses Variation** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nxc6 bxc6 6.e5
- **Tartakower Variation** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Nf6 5.Nxc6 bxc6 6.Nd2
- **Vitzthum Attack** C44
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Bc4 Bc5 5.Ng5 Nh6 6.Qh5
- **Cochrane Variation** C44
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Bc4 Bb4 5.c3 dxc3 6.bxc3 Ba5 7.e5
- **Meitner Variation** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Nge7 7.Nc2
- **Paulsen Attack** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Nge7 7.Bb5
- **Paulsen** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Nge7 7.Bb5 Nd8
  - **Gunsberg Defense** C45
    1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Nge7 7.Bb5 Nd8
- **Cochrane-Shumov Defense** C44
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Bc4 Bc5 5.Ng5 Nh6 6.Nxf7 Nxf7 7.Bxf7 Kxf7 8.Qh5 g6 9.Qxc5 d5
- **Hanneken Variation** C44
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Bc4 Bb4 5.c3 dxc3 6.O-O cxb2 7.Bxb2 Nf6 8.Ng5 O-O 9.e5 Nxe5
- **Rosenthal Variation** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Qh4 5.Nb5 Bb4 6.Bd2 Qxe4 7.Be2 Kd8 8.O-O Bxd2 9.Nxd2 Qg6
- **Sea-Cadet Mate** C44
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.c3 dxc3 5.Nxc3 d6 6.Bc4 Bg4 7.O-O Ne5 8.Nxe5 Bxd1 9.Bxf7 Ke7 10.Nd5
- **Gottschall Variation** C45
  1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 -> 3...exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6 6.c3 Nge7 7.Qd2 d5 8.Nb5 Bxe3 9.Qxe3 O-O 10.Nxc7 Rb8 11.Nx…

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4 Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6
```

Plan chain

White	Nf3 -> Nc3 -> d4 -> Bc4 -> Bd3
Black	Nc6 -> Nf6 -> d5 -> Be7 -> Bc5

Three rules to remember

1. Knights, bishops, castle, then open the center when ahead in development.
2. Complete development, castle, then open the center or attack the weak point.
3. The side with the initiative wants to open lines; the defender wants to neutralize with ...d5 or ...Nf6.

Pawn structure in one line

Open centre: lines open early, so development and king safety dominate. Structures range from open centres to gambit positions.